

A RIGHTS ISSUE File pix of a Lingayat Mahamorcha rally in Mumbai

▶ MAHARASHTRA

IDENTITY FLUX

The caste census sets the field rife with calls to action. The Lingayats demand a separate religion, Buddhist Dalits want a new consolidation

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IN THE SCIENCES, THERE'S A THING THEY call the observer's paradox. It says a subject of study is transformed by the very act of observing it. Maharashtra could well be offering a live demo of this ahead of Census 2027. The state has already seen the modern inversion of what sociologists once called 'Sanskritisation'. The Maratha protests for a downward shift of caste slot revealed a social field where identity is strong and fixed, but categories are mobile. Now, as India gets set to enumerate caste groups for the first time in almost a century, this trend is deepening—and spilling out laterally. Categories are threatening to breach their embankments in ways that could roil India's polity in fundamental ways.

Look at how the Lingayats and Buddhist Dalits are upping their ante. The census is in its first phase—the 'House Listing and Housing Census' began in April and will last till September. But already, identity-based groups are mobilising for phase two, where, beginning February 2027, caste will be counted. Their leaders have begun reaching out to their flock: the message being relayed is about 'how' to write down 'who' they are. And it seems the religion column next to caste is not insulated from it.

A 10 MILLION QUESTION

The Lingayats are proving to be a live-wire case. Often thought to be exclusive to Karnataka, they are in fact a big presence in western Maharashtra and Marathwada—numbering around 10